CASTRO DUG IN HIS HEELS. HE WAS DETERMINED TO CONDUCT his own foreign policy and establish himself as an independent actor in the international arena. He demonstrated his full independence not only from the United States but also from the Soviet Union when, on the afternoon of October 30, he welcomed to the presidential palace in Havana a distinguished guest from New York, Secretary General of the United Nations U Thant.

The United Nations was a major battleground in the struggle for public support between the Soviet Union and Cuba on the one hand and the United States and its allies on the other. Adlai Stevenson's presentation of U-2 photos of Soviet missile sites and his confrontation with the Soviet ambassador, Valerian Zorin, was the most spectacular episode of that struggle, but the struggle itself was not limited to dramas of that kind. The acting secretary general of the United Nations, the Burmese diplomat U Thant, played an important role in keeping the crisis from escalating into an open confrontation. U Thant was the first to publicly suggest a solution to the crisis—withdrawal of the Soviet missiles in exchange for an American pledge not to attack Cuba—which he promoted both publicly and privately.[17]

For quite some time, the Americans encouraged U Thant to propose UN inspection of the Cuban missile sites, but Khrushchev never consulted with the secretary general on whether he would assume that role before accepting Kennedy's proposal that the missiles be withdrawn under UN supervision. Once he had accepted the proposal, however, Khrushchev instructed Gromyko to deliver the news not only to Robert Kennedy via Dobrynin but also to U Thant through the Soviet representative at the UN, Valerian Zorin. On the same day, October 28, U Thant wrote to Khrushchev expressing his "extreme satisfaction" with the Soviet leader's decision to dismantle the missile sites and his readiness "to reach an agreement about the possibility of UN representatives checking on the dismantling of these bases."[18]

Fidel Castro invited U Thant to visit Cuba on October 27, in the middle of the war scare that engulfed both him and the Soviet commanders on the island. He needed the secretary general not only as an intermediary, writing that he was prepared to discuss his differences with the United States, but also as a shield against invasion. By the time U Thant accepted the